

H O R S D ' O E U V R E S | D I L I P B O B B

India's Trust Deficit

The headlines relating to the prime minister's press conference were about his statement on the 'trust deficit' with Pakistan. It's become another of those catchphrases to enter the diplomatic dictionary, along with 'war on terror' and 'known unknowns'. There is, however, a sub-text to the issue of being worthy of trust. A recent all-India survey by *Reader's Digest* ranked Manmohan Singh seventh in a list of 100 people Indians trust the most. One would have presumed he would have ranked higher than A.R. Rahman (5) or Kiran Bedi (3), but such is the power of perception and the influencing of public opinion by the media which has generally portrayed him as being weak and powerless, even if the truth is somewhat different. Ironically, the same survey ranked journalists way down on a supplementary list of most trusted professions, below plumbers and electricians.

There's a bit of reverse osmosis involved: such rankings also hold a mirror to society. The 10 most trusted are headed by ex-President APJ Abdul Kalam followed by Ratan Tata, Bedi, who retired from active police service a decade ago but has a TV show where she settles real-life disputes, N.R. Narayana Murthy, Viswanathan Anand, Sachin Tendulkar, R.K. Laxman, who has been out of action for some years, and Azim Premji. It's an odd list: four people (including Murthy) are retired, three are business leaders (ranked 23rd out of 40 in the profession list), and two sportsmen in the twilight of their careers. How does Indian society rank in terms of those choices? One is that we prefer safe and conventional over risk-taking and out-of-the-box thinkers or doers. That explains why business leaders like the Ambani brothers or Sunil Mittal rank way down as does M.S. Dhoni, Lalit Modi (this was done before he lost his job) and M.F. Husain. The toppers—Ratan Tata, Murthy, Premji—run perhaps the most respected companies in India but are hardly adventurous types. In contrast, successive Gallup polls in the US have ranked Apple's Steve Jobs, innovator and risk-taker, Warren Buffet, legendary investor, and maverick politician Sarah Palin, in the top five.

Further, in India, success doesn't readily translate into trust: it must go along with impeachable reputations, again highly subjective but applicable to Kalam, Murthy, Tata, Premji, Anand and Tendulkar. Dhoni's flamboyance rules him out, ditto for the

Modis'—Lalit and Gujarat's Narendra—and it also explains why a low key Aamir Khan ranks much higher than a mega-profile SRK. It appears we like our role models to be plain vanilla rather than risk-laden chocolates, family-men who dress conventionally and rarely appear in public as opposed to those who reflect ostentatious living. To me the bottomline is that most Indians are still stuck in the Hindu rate of growth mindset where baby steps are preferable to audacious leaps of ambition and endeavour. Trust me on that.



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STAYED: By the Supreme Court the death sentence awarded to gangster-terrorist **Aftab Ahmed Ansari** for the attack on the American Centre in Kolkata in 2002.



ELECTED: Indian-origin **Kamla Persad-Bissessar** as the first woman prime minister of Trinidad and Tobago. The political coalition led by her ended the ruling Government's 43 years in power.

DIED: Former advocate general of Uttar Pradesh and sitting **Rajya Sabha** MP of the Samajwadi Party **Virendra Bhatia** (63). He became a member of the Upper House in 2006.

CIRCUMNAVIGATED: **Commander Dilip Donde** (42), of the Indian Navy, the globe on a sailboat. The first Indian to do so, Donde covered 21,600 nautical miles sailing in the seas to achieve the milestone.

